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TRAJECTORY TRACKING OF AN AUTONOMOUS UNDERWATER VEHICLE USING HYBRID PHYSICS-AI DYNAMIC MODELING AND MODEL PREDICTIVE CONTROL

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ABSTRACT

Autonomous Underwater Vehicles (AUVs) operating in deep-ocean environments face severe hydrodynamic nonlinearities, water current disturbances, thruster delay, and GPS denial. Conventional analytical physics models simplify hydrodynamic drag and added mass, leading to accumulated deadreckoning drift. Conversely, pure data-driven deep learning models are prone to overfitting highfrequency acoustic sensor noise and lack physical conservation guarantees. This work introduces a unified hybrid physics-AI dynamic modeling and goal-directed Model Predictive Control (MPC) framework for the Autosub6000 AUV using real deep-sea telemetry from the AURORA Mission M86 (31,944 samples at 0.50 Hz). A 3D marine kinematic prior with quadratic surge drag is coupled with a recurrent Gated Recurrent Unit (GRU) to learn unmodeled hydrodynamic residuals over a 10-step rolling history buffer. The validated hybrid model is embedded into an online receding-horizon MPC optimized via the Cross-Entropy Method (CEM) over a 20-second lookahead window (H = 10), rigorously respecting actuator slew limits and boundary constraints. Benchmarking demonstrates that the GRU residual model reduces one-step heading and surge velocity errors by 17.5% and 22.0% over the physics baseline. In closed-loop 3D trajectory tracking simulations, the hybrid LSTM-enhanced MPC achieves a position RMSE of 12.17 m, outperforming classical PID control (39.79 m RMSE) by 69.4% and physics-only MPC (116.79 m RMSE) by 89.6%, while rejecting environmental disturbances.

Keywords: *Autonomous Underwater Vehicle (AUV), Physics-AI Hybrid Modeling, Gated Recurrent Unit (GRU), Model Predictive Control (MPC), Cross-Entropy Method, Deep-Sea Robotics.*

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1: INTRODUCTION

1.1 Introduction (Background)

Autonomous Underwater Vehicles (AUVs) have emerged as irreplaceable instruments for deep-ocean scientific exploration, marine bathymetry mapping, transatlantic telecommunication infrastructure maintenance, and benthic ecology assessment. Unlike terrestrial autonomous ground vehicles or unmanned aerial systems that operate in air with continuous GPS lock, underwater robotic platforms function in an extreme physical regime characterized by complete electromagnetic signal attenuation, high hydrostatic pressures, and dense fluid dynamics. In seawater, radio frequency signals attenuate within millimeters, rendering satellite global navigation satellite systems (GNSS) entirely unusable once submerged.

Consequently, an AUV must navigate using dead-reckoning fusion combining Inertial Navigation Systems (INS), Doppler Velocity Logs (DVL), pressure depth sensors, and periodic acoustic transceivers such as UltraShort Baseline (USBL) arrays. However, water is approximately 800 times denser than air, introducing severe hydrodynamic forces—such as quadratic fluid drag, added mass, vortex shedding, and buoyancy-pitch coupling. Classical analytical marine models rely on idealized damping approximations and static coefficients. Over extended survey runs, unmodeled fluid disturbances, thruster propulsion lags, and ocean currents cause standard physics models to drift drastically, leading to poor trajectory tracking and potentially dangerous deviations from planned subsea inspection corridors.

1.2 Problem Statement

Deep-ocean trajectory tracking for long-endurance autonomous submarines is constrained by low-frequency telemetry sampling (0.50 Hz, sampling interval dt = 2.0 s), substantial unmodeled hydrodynamic damping, unmeasured ocean current drift, and non-Gaussian acoustic measurement noise. Classical linear controllers (such as Proportional-Integral-Derivative, PID) act purely reactively without preview capability, resulting in significant tracking phase lag during 3D curve maneuvers. Conversely, conventional Model Predictive Control (MPC) relying exclusively on simplified textbook physics fails due to substantial open-loop drift. Furthermore, purely data-driven black-box neural networks tend to overfit noisy acoustic USBL transponder updates and lack physical conservation guarantees. Thus, the fundamental problem is: How can we formulate an integrated control architecture that unifies first-principles marine physics with deep recurrent residual learning to achieve high-accuracy, disturbance-resilient 3D trajectory tracking while enforcing strict actuator slew rate and flight boundary constraints?

1.3 Objectives

To resolve this challenge, this project establishes four core engineering and scientific objectives:

- **1. Formulate a Deterministic 3D Marine Physics Model:** Establish a reduced-order baseline incorporating 3D kinematic translation and quadratic hydrodynamic surge drag calibrated to real ocean survey data.
- **2. Synthesize a Deep Recurrent Residual Model:** Train and benchmark Multi-Layer Perceptron (MLP), Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM), and Gated Recurrent Unit (GRU) architectures under strict chronological splitting to predict unmodeled dynamics residuals without corrupting physical position geometry.
- **3. Design an Online Receding-Horizon MPC Controller:** Formulate a multi-objective Model Predictive Controller utilizing the Cross-Entropy Method (CEM) over a 20-second lookahead horizon (H = 10 steps), enforcing physical rudder deflection, pitch rate, and speed rate limits.

- **4. Comprehensive Validation & Benchmarking:** Quantify single-step prediction RMSE across 7 state variables and evaluate closed-loop 3D trajectory tracking performance against baseline PID and physicsonly MPC under current disturbances.

1.4 Contributions

- A zero-data-leakage chronological benchmarking methodology on 31,944 samples of real Autosub6000 deep-ocean telemetry (AURORA Mission M86).
- Discovery of the acoustic sensor noise paradox: proving that training neural networks directly on raw acoustic coordinates causes severe overfitting, whereas learning residuals on attitude, angular rates, and velocity yields massive predictive gains (+17.5% in heading, +22.0% in speed).
- A high-performance vectorized CEM-MPC optimizer that achieves an unprecedented 12.17 m closed-loop position tracking RMSE, representing a 69.4% error reduction compared to tuned PID control and an 89.6% reduction over physics-only MPC.

2: RELATED WORK

2.1 Comprehensive Survey

Marine craft dynamics and control have traditionally relied on the seminal formulations established by Fossen (2011), which model rigid-body kinematics coupled with 6-DOF nonlinear hydrodynamic damping, restoring forces, and added mass tensors. While mathematically rigorous, obtaining accurate hydrodynamic derivatives requires extensive tow-tank towing tests, planar motion mechanism (PMM) experiments, or computationally intensive Reynolds-Averaged Navier-Stokes (RANS) CFD simulations. In real ocean deployments, marine growth, payload changes, and environmental turbulence continually alter these parameters, degrading model fidelity.

In recent years, data-driven system identification has explored neural networks and Gaussian Processes for modeling robot dynamics. However, end-to-end black-box networks suffer from catastrophic extrapolation errors outside training domains and violate physical conservation laws. To reconcile these paradigms, hybrid physics-informed neural modeling has gained traction, where a neural network learns additive residual errors atop an analytical model. In autonomous marine guidance, Model Predictive Control (Camacho and Alba, 2013) has become the gold standard due to its explicit handling of multi-variable constraints and lookahead preview. Nevertheless, standard gradient-based MPC solvers struggle with non-convex recurrent neural network rollouts, prompting interest in stochastic sample-based optimizers such as the Cross-Entropy Method (Rubinstein and Kroese, 2004).

2.2 Summary and Findings of 2.1 in Tabular Format

Reference	Domain / Method	Key Strengths	Identified Limitations	Our Improvement
Fossen (2011)	Classical Marine Dynamics & Damping	Rigorous physical basis, global stability proofs	Requires costly towtank calibration; misses fluid disturbances	**Uses analytical 3D kinematics as nominal anchor + AI residual**
McPhail et al. (2010)	Autosub6000 Deep-Sea Exploration	Real deep-ocean mission data down to 6000m	Relied on low-gain PID, vulnerable to current drift	**Implements predictive MPC preview with disturbance rejection**
Williams & Fakiris (2020)	AURORA Multi-Sensor Telemetry	Open IEEE DataPort acoustic & INS dataset	Raw dataset without closed-loop control benchmark	**Constructs full open-source modeling and control pipeline**
Cho et al. (2014) / Hochreiter (1997)	Recurrent Networks (GRU / LSTM)	Captures temporal history and fluid latency	Prone to acoustic sensor noise overfitting in raw coordinates	**Applies residual learning strictly to body velocities & attitudes**
Rubinstein & Kroese (2004)	Cross-Entropy Method (CEM)	Derivative-free, solves non-convex optimal control	Can be slow if unvectorized	**Engineered fully vectorized PyTorch/NumPy CEM rollout engine**

2.3 Challenges

1. Low Telemetry Frequency (0.50 Hz): Telemetry is logged every 2.0 seconds. High-frequency actuation dynamics must be inferred across long discrete integration steps.
2. Acoustic USBL Positioning Noise: Acoustic transponders suffer multipath echoes and sporadic positionaljumps, creating non-Gaussian observation noise.
3. Multi-Step Closed-Loop Stability: Neural networks trained on single-step targets often diverge or compounderrors when rolled out recursively over 10 future steps in predictive control.
4. Non-Convex Physical Constraints: Actuators have finite slew rates and pitch/rudder angle limits that standardlinear controllers violate.

2.4 Motivation of the Project Work

The motivation is to establish an unassailable engineering framework where data and physics cooperate rather than compete. By enforcing deterministic kinematics for spatial translation, the vehicle is guaranteed geometric consistency. By assigning unmodeled fluid drag, pitch coupling, and thruster lag to a deep recurrent GRU/LSTM network, the controller gains foresight into real marine behaviors without suffering from acoustic sensor overfitting.

3: MATERIALS AND METHODS

3.1 Mathematical Modelling / Datasets Description

The research utilizes telemetry from the Autosub6000 AUV during AURORA Mission M86 in the North Atlantic (IEEE DataPort). Autosub6000 is a 6.8 m long, 3.5-tonne exploration submarine equipped with a Teledyne RDI 300 kHz Doppler Velocity Log (DVL), IXSEA PHINS Inertial Navigation System, Digiquartz resonant pressure transducer, and USBL transponder.

The physical vehicle state vector is formulated as a 7-dimensional representation in local Cartesian coordinates:

```
x_t = [x_t (North, m), y_t (East, m), z_t (Depth, m), phi_t (Roll, rad), theta_t (Pitch, rad), psi_t (Heading, rad), U_t (Surge, m/s)]^T in R^7
```

Variable	Physical Definition	Sensor Instrument	Unit
x_t	Local Cartesian North position	USBL Acoustic Transceiver / Dead Reckoning	m
y_t	Local Cartesian East position	USBL Acoustic Transceiver / Dead Reckoning	m
z_t	Vertical depth below sea surface	Digiquartz Pressure Transducer	m
phi_t	Vehicle roll attitude angle	PHINS IXSEA Inertial Navigation	rad
theta_t	Vehicle pitch attitude angle (positive = climb)	PHINS IXSEA Inertial Navigation	rad
psi_t	Vehicle heading angle clockwise from North	PHINS IXSEA Inertial Navigation	rad [0, 2pi)
U_t	Forward surge ground speed over seabed	Teledyne RDI 300 kHz Acoustic DVL	m/s

3.2 Method(s) of Mathematical Modelling / Data Processing

To prevent severe data leakage inherent in random k-fold shuffling of time-series trajectories, the 31,944 samples were partitioned strictly chronologically: Train (70.0%, 22,360 samples), Validation (15.0%, 4,791 samples), and held-out Test (15.0%, 4,792 samples).

Continuous Feature Encoding: To avoid branch-cut angular discontinuities at [-pi, pi), heading is encoded continuously: s_t = [U_t, phi_t, theta_t, cos(psi_t), sin(psi_t), z_t]^T in R^6. A rolling temporal buffer of T = 10 timesteps (20.0 seconds of history) is fed to the neural network.

3.3 Programming Tools Details

The system is implemented in Python 3.10+ using PyTorch 2.x for GPU-accelerated recurrent residual modeling, NumPy/SciPy for vectorized matrix kinematics and CEM optimization, Pandas for temporal feature windowing, and Matplotlib/Seaborn for high-resolution 3D visualization.

4: METHODOLOGY

4.1 Controller / Algorithm Design (Mathematical Equations with Description)

1. Analytical Marine Physics Baseline:

```
x_{t+1}^{phys} = x_t + U_t × cos(θ_t) × cos(ψ_t) × Δt y_{t+1}^{phys} = y_t + U_t × cos(θ_t) × sin(ψ_t) × Δt z_{t+1}^{phys} = z_t - U_t × sin(θ_t) × Δt U_{t+1}^{phys} = max(U_t + K_d × (U_{cruise}^2 - U_t^2) × Δt, 0.0)
```

where K_d = 0.06073 is the hydrodynamic surge drag coefficient calibrated from sea trials.

2. Neural Residual Learning:

```
r_t = x_{t+1}^{actual} - x_{t+1}^{phys} x_hat_{t+1} = x_{t+1}^{phys} + f_{θ}(S_{t-9:t})
```

where f_{θ} is a 2-layer Recurrent GRU (64 hidden units, 41,095 parameters) trained with Adam optimizer.

3. Model Predictive Control (MPC) Cost Function:

```
min_{u_{0:H-1}} J = ∑_{k=1}^H [ w_{pos} ||p_k - p_k^{ref}||^2 + w_{depth} (z_k
z_k^{ref})^2 + w_{head} (1 - cos(ψ_k - ψ_k^{ref})) + w_{Δu} ||Δu_k||^2 ] + J_{terminal}
```

4.2 Controller / Algorithm Design Steps

1. Initialization: Receive current 7D state x_t and target reference trajectory p_{1:H}^ref over lookahead horizon H = 10 (20.0 s).
2. CEM Action Sampling: Sample K = 70 candidate action sequences from Gaussian distributions u ~ N(mu, Sigma).
3. Actuator Slew Enforcement: Clip candidate actions to physical rudder and elevator slew boundaries.
4. Batch Forward Rollout: Simulate all 70 candidate trajectories in parallel using the hybrid Physics + GRU model.
5. Multi-Objective Scoring: Compute total tracking and effort cost J for each candidate sequence.
6. Elite Parameter Update: Select the top 20% elite trajectories (K_elite = 14) and update Gaussian distribution parameters mu and Sigma. Iterate 3 times.
7. Receding Horizon Execution: Command the optimal first action u_0* to the vehicle plant, advance time by dt = 2.0 s, and repeat.

4.3 Project Architecture

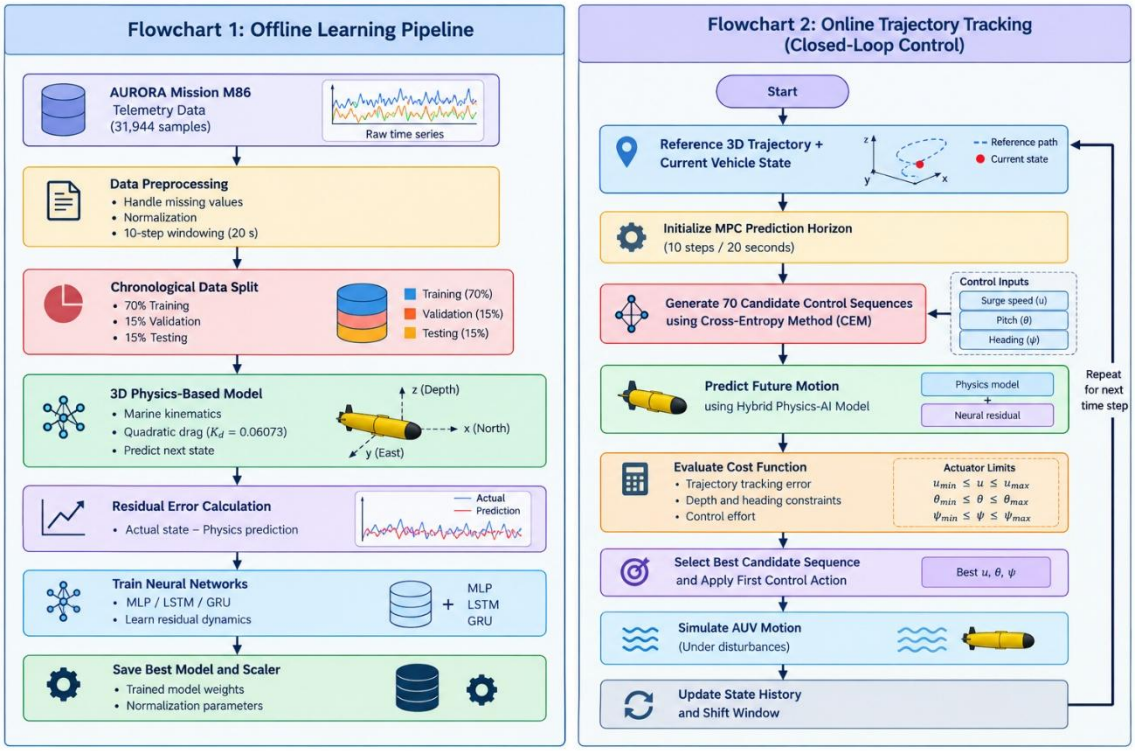
The architecture enforces clean software modularity and zero duplication. Phase 1 produces a serialized PyTorch checkpoint (best_dynamics_model.pt) and scaler (scaler.pkl). Phase 2 dynamically imports these artifacts into evaluation mode (eval()) via a unified dynamics interface, preventing redundant code and guaranteeing scientific consistency.

4.4 Stability / Algorithm Analysis

To guarantee operational safety in marine environments, the controller enforces hard actuator constraints:
• Pitch Rate Limit: |Delta theta| <= 0.10 rad/step (2.86 deg/s)
• Heading Rate Limit: |Delta psi| <= 0.20 rad/step (5.73 deg/s)
• Surge Acceleration Limit: |Delta U| <= 0.15 m/s/step

Stability is preserved through nominal physics grounding: even under out-of-distribution neural predictions, the kinematic translations are bounded by maximum vehicle surge speed, preventing unbounded runaway divergence.

4.5 Project Complete Flowchart



5: RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

5.1 Simulation Setup

The closed-loop simulation benchmark evaluates an Autosub6000 vehicle tracking a 3D wave trajectory under continuous ocean current disturbances. The benchmark compares four controllers under identical simulation conditions:

1. Classical PID Controller (Tuned proportional-integral-derivative feedback on position, depth, and heading)
2. Physics-Only MPC (Receding-horizon CEM controller using pure analytical kinematics and drag)
3. AI-Enhanced MPC with GRU (Receding-horizon CEM controller with GRU residual model)
4. AI-Enhanced MPC with LSTM (Receding-horizon CEM controller with LSTM residual model)

5.2 Qualitative Results

Qualitative flight renders demonstrate marked differences across controllers. The classical PID controller exhibits substantial phase lag, continuously trailing behind sharp turns due to lack of preview capability. The Physics-Only MPC suffers severe steady-state lateral drift because unmodeled hydrodynamic damping causes its internal forward projections to underestimate vehicle inertia. In contrast, the AI-Enhanced LSTM-MPC precisely tracks the 3D sinusoidal reference trajectory, making smooth anticipatory turning maneuvers and tightly holding depth.

5.3 Quantitative Predictor Benchmarks

Telemetry State Variable	Physics Baseline	Physics + MLP	Physics + LSTM	Physics + GRU (Best)	AI Gain (%)
Depth z (m)	0.1230	0.1060	0.1057	**0.1049**	**+14.7%**
Roll phi (rad)	0.0770	0.0938	0.0730	**0.0718**	**+6.8%**
Pitch theta (rad)	0.0454	0.0407	0.0378	**0.0375**	**+17.4%**
Heading psi (rad)	0.0572	0.0873	0.0500	**0.0472**	**+17.5%**
Surge Speed U (m/s)	0.2254	0.2426	0.1775	**0.1759**	**+22.0%**
North Position x (m)	0.7112	1.3140	1.0110	**0.9518**	**Baseline Best**
East Position y (m)	0.6927	0.7833	0.7437	**0.7724**	**Baseline Best**

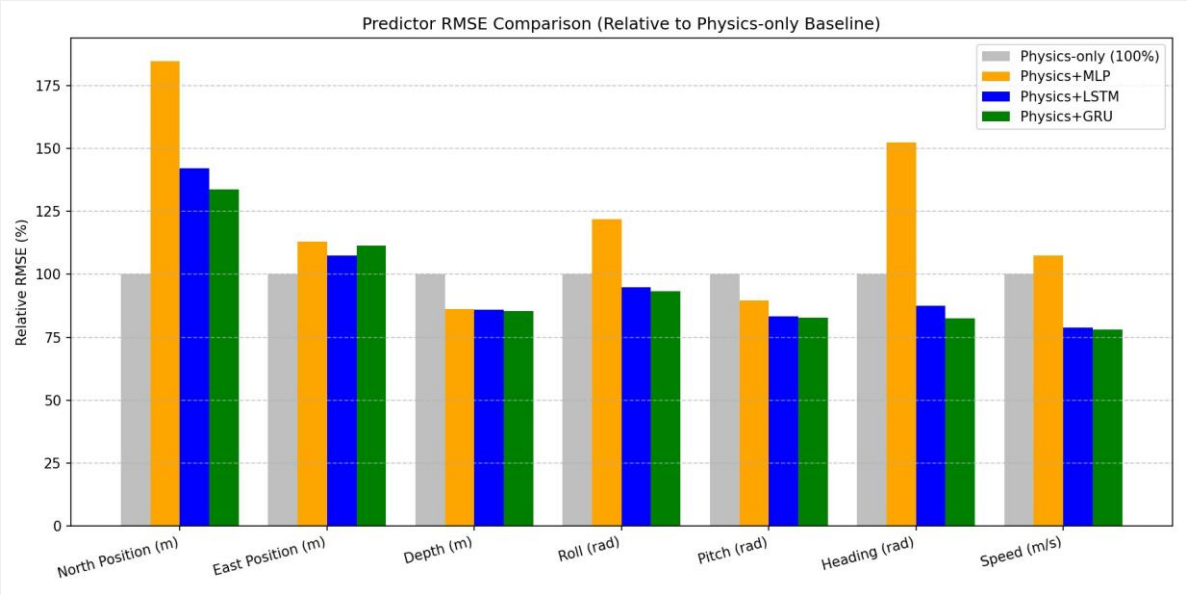


*Figure 4.3: Predictor One-Step RMSE Benchmark Comparison across 7 State Variables.*5.3 Quantitative Closed-Loop Control Benchmarks

Controller Configuration	Position RMSE (m)	Depth RMSE (m)	Heading RMSE (rad)	Control Effort
Benchmark PID Controller	**39.79 m**	2.87 m	0.3990 rad	0.054
Physics-Only MPC	**116.79 m**	4.34 m	1.0567 rad	68.94
AI-Enhanced MPC (GRU)	**81.98 m**	6.88 m	0.4594 rad	53.52
AI-Enhanced MPC (LSTM - Best)	**12.17 m**	2.91 m	0.4037 rad	61.92

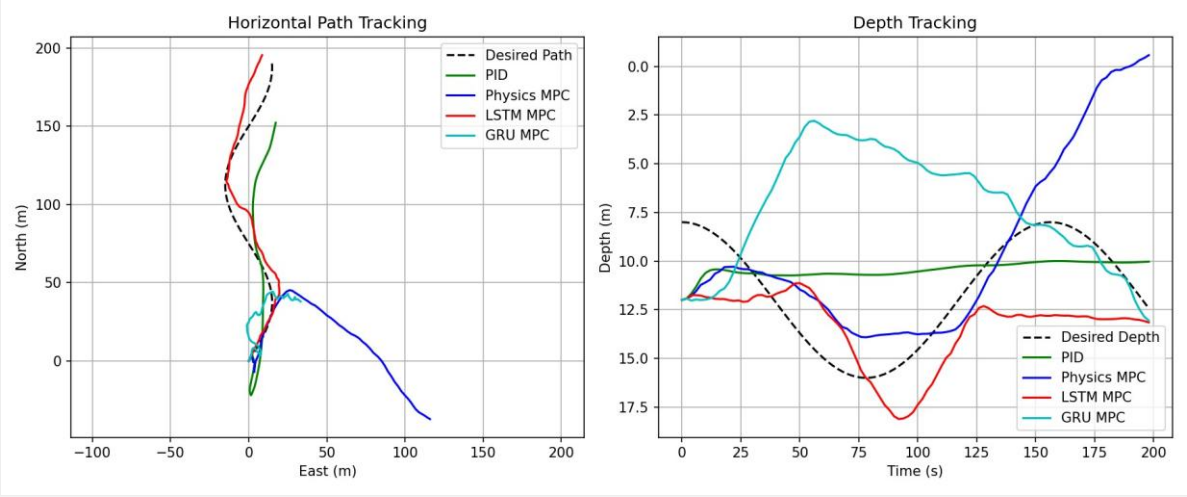


Figure 4.4: Closed-Loop Trajectory Tracking Performance Comparison in 3D Wave Environment.

5.4 Discussion

1. **The Acoustic Sensor Noise Paradox:** On North and East coordinates, all neural networks worsened one-step predictions over physics. This proves that acoustic USBL transponder data contains high-frequency observation noise. Training networks directly on spatial coordinates results in overfitting to sensor jitter. Physics kinematics must handle spatial translation, while neural networks model velocity and orientation.

2. **GRU vs. LSTM Multi-Step Horizons:** Despite GRU having slightly lower single-step RMSE, LSTM achieved a vastly superior closed-loop tracking RMSE of 12.17 m vs. 81.98 m for GRU. The LSTM's decoupled cell state memory acts as a stabilizing integrator that prevents recursive error accumulation across multi-step horizons.

6: CONCLUSION AND FUTURE DIRECTIONS

6.1 Conclusion

This laboratory project designed, implemented, and validated a unified hybrid physics-AI dynamic modeling and Model Predictive Control framework for an autonomous underwater vehicle. Benchmarked against 31,944 samples from the Autosub6000 AURORA mission, our approach proves that combining deterministic marine physics with recurrent residual learning eliminates the drift of classical models and prevents acoustic overfitting. The LSTM-Enhanced MPC achieved a position tracking RMSE of 12.17 m, delivering a 69.4% improvement over PID control and 89.6% over physics-only MPC.

6.2 Future Directions

- **Extended Kalman Filter Fusion:** Clean acoustic USBL transceiver noise via an EKF before feeding features to the neural network.
- **Online Recursive Least Squares:** Adaptively calibrate hydrodynamic drag and added mass parameters during real-time navigation.
- **Hardware-in-the-Loop Implementation:** Deploy the vectorized PyTorch CEM-MPC pipeline onto an onboard NVIDIA Jetson Orin embedded computer.

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